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SonicWall urges customers to disable SSLVPN amid reports of ransomware attacks

Enterprise security company SonicWall is urging its customers to disable a core feature of its most recent line-up of firewall devices after security researchers reported an uptick in ransomware incidents targeting SonicWall customers.

In [a statement this week](#), SonicWall said it had observed a “notable increase” of security incidents targeting its Generation 7 firewalls where customers have its VPN enabled. The company said it is “actively investigating these incidents to determine whether they are connected to a previously disclosed vulnerability or if a new vulnerability may be responsible.”

IMAGE CREDITS: BORTONIA / GETTY IMAGES

The company’s alert comes as security researchers say they have identified hackers targeting SonicWall devices to gain initial access to a victim’s network.

Hackers are [increasingly targeting enterprise products](#), like firewalls and VPNs, which work as digital gatekeepers, allowing legitimate employees access to the company’s network. But security flaws in these products can allow malicious hackers in, enabling attackers to launch data-stealing or destructive attacks.

Security firm Arctic Wolf [said it has seen intrusions](#) targeting SonicWall customers as far back as mid-July. The company said “available evidence points to the existence of a zero-day vulnerability,”

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referring to a security bug that was discovered and exploited before the vendor could patch the issue.

The researchers said they witnessed a short gap between the exploitation of the SonicWall firewall and the subsequent deployment of file-encrypting malware, or ransomware.

Huntress Labs, another cybersecurity firm, said it [is “likely” that a zero-day bug in SonicWall firewalls is to blame](#) for the attacks, and warned that the hackers exploiting the bug have been seen gaining access to a company’s domain controllers, which manages the devices and users on that network.

In its blog, Huntress said it believes the Akira ransomware gang is behind some of the attacks targeting SonicWall customers. Akira has been known to target enterprise products, [like Fortinet firewalls](#), to break into large networks.

“This is a critical, ongoing threat,” wrote Huntress.

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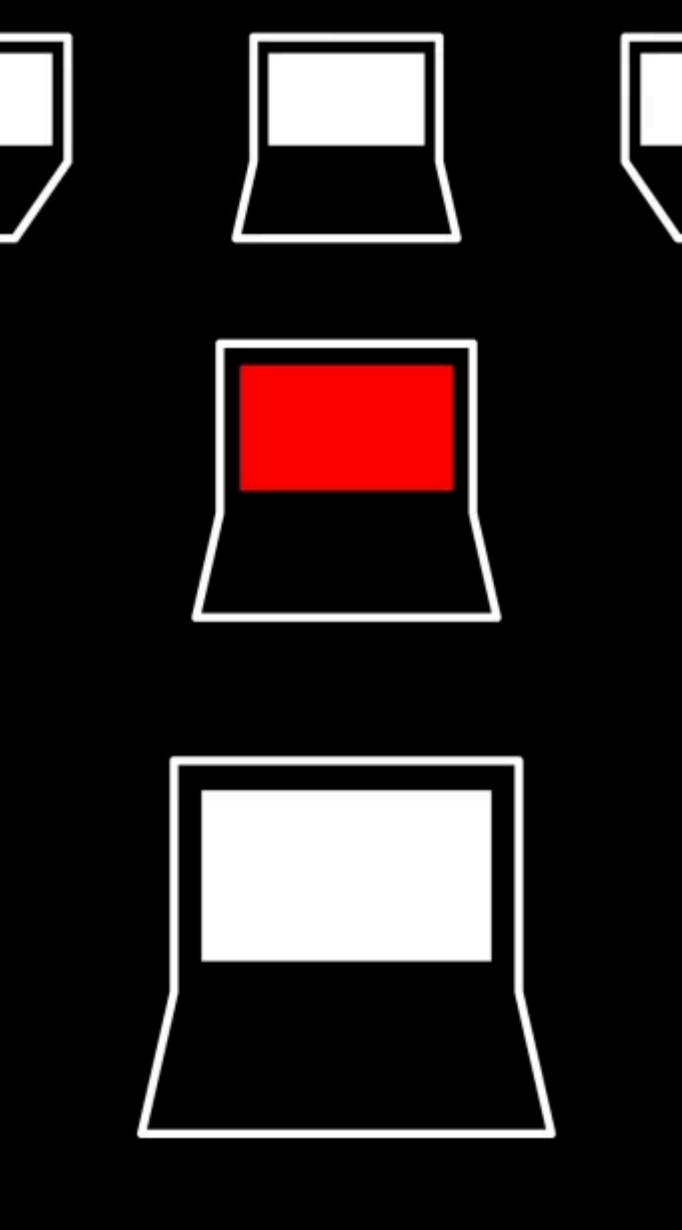


IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

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SonicWall says hackers are exploiting a new zero-day bug to breach customer networks

Zack Whittaker — 3:25 PM PST · January 27, 2025

Cybersecurity company SonicWall says hackers are exploiting a newly discovered vulnerability in one of its enterprise products to break into its customers' corporate networks.

SonicWall said [in an advisory](#) that the vulnerability in its SMA1000 remote access appliance, which companies use to allow their employees to remotely log in to their corporate networks as if they were in the office, allows anyone over the internet to plant malware on affected devices without needing a login for the system.

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The vulnerability, tracked as CVE-2025-23006, was discovered by Microsoft and shared with SonicWall last week. In [a subsequent support post](#), SonicWall said the vulnerability is “confirmed as being actively exploited in the wild,” indicating that some of SonicWall’s corporate customers had been hacked. The bug is known as a [zero day](#) because it was exploited before SonicWall had time to provide customers with a fix.

When contacted by TechCrunch, neither SonicWall nor Microsoft said how many companies had their networks compromised in the attacks, but urged customers to patch affected systems by installing the security hotfix that SonicWall has since released.

Close to a hundred SMA 1000 appliances with vulnerable consoles are exposed to the internet, [according to Censys researchers](#), putting many of those companies with unpatched systems at greater risk of attacks.

Malicious hackers are increasingly targeting corporate cybersecurity products, such as firewalls, remote access tools, and VPN products. These devices exist on the perimeter of corporate networks to protect against would-be intruders and unauthorized access. But they also have a propensity to contain software bugs that can render their security protections ineffective, allowing hackers to compromise the very networks that these devices were tasked with protecting.

In recent years, some of the biggest makers of corporate cybersecurity products, including [Barracuda](#), [Check Point](#), [Cisco](#), [Citrix](#), [Fortinet](#), [Ivanti](#), and [Palo Alto Networks](#), have disclosed zero-day attacks targeting their customers, which have resulted in broader network compromises.

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According to U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA, the [top most routinely exploited vulnerabilities](#) during 2023 were found in enterprise products developed by Citrix, Cisco, and Fortinet, and used by hackers to conduct operations against “high-priority targets.”

Updated on January 28 with new data from Censys on the number of affected devices.

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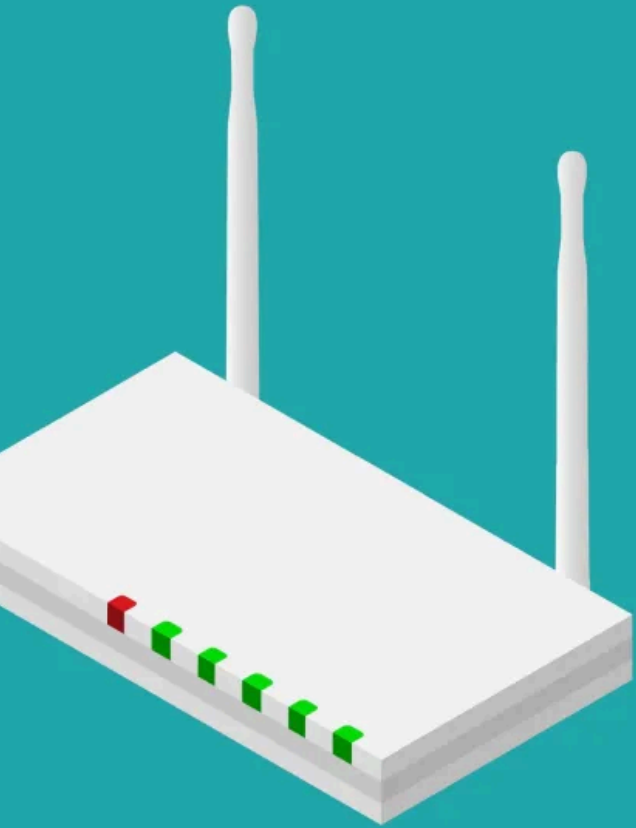
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A SonicWall cloud bug exposed corporate networks to hackers

Zack Whittaker — 6:00 AM PDT · September 2, 2020

A newly discovered bug in a cloud system used to manage SonicWall firewalls could have allowed hackers to break into thousands of corporate networks.

IMAGE CREDITS: [DEDY SETYAWAN](#) / GETTY IMAGES

Enterprise firewalls and virtual private network appliances are vital gatekeepers tasked with protecting corporate networks from hackers and cyberattacks while still letting in employees working from home during the pandemic. Even though most offices are empty, hackers frequently [look for bugs](#) in critical network gear in order to break into company networks to steal data or plant malware.

Vangelis Stykas, a researcher at security firm Pen Test Partners, found the new bug in SonicWall's Global Management System (GMS), a web app that lets IT departments remotely configure their SonicWall devices across the network.

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But the bug, if exploited, meant any existing user with access to SonicWall's GMS could create a user account with access to any other company's network without permission.

From there, the newly created account could remotely manage the SonicWall gear of that company.

In [a blog post](#) shared with TechCrunch, Stykas said there were two barriers to entry. Firstly, a would-be attacker would need an existing SonicWall GMS user account. The easiest way — and what Stykas did to independently test the bug — was to buy a SonicWall device.

The second issue was that the would-be attacker would also need to guess a unique seven-digit number associated with another company's network. But Stykas said that this number appeared to be sequential and could be easily enumerated, one after the other.

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Once inside a company's network, the attacker could deliver ransomware directly to the internal systems of their victims, an [increasingly popular tactic](#) for financially driven hackers.

SonicWall confirmed the bug is now fixed. But Stykas criticized the company for taking more than two weeks to patch the vulnerability, which he described as "trivial" to exploit.

"Even car alarm vendors have fixed similar issues inside three days of us reporting," he wrote.

A SonicWall spokesperson defended the decision to subject the fix to a "full" quality check before it was rolled out, and said it is "not aware" of any exploitation of the vulnerability.

[As ransomware gets craftier, companies must start thinking creatively](#)

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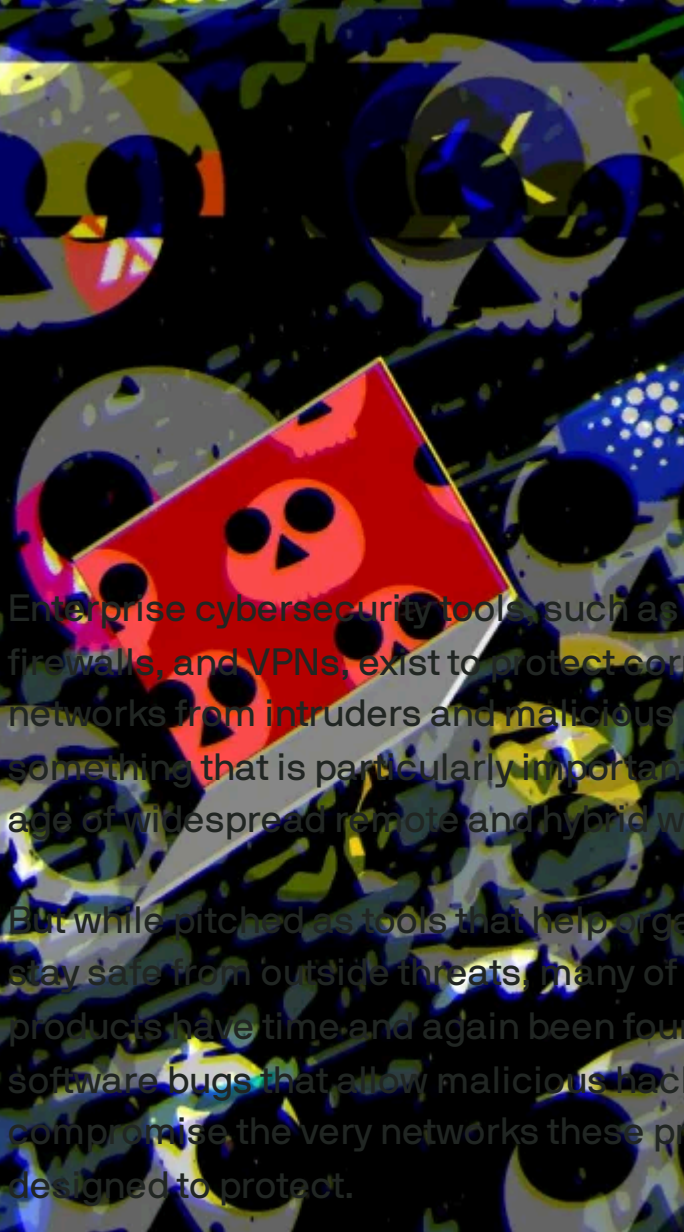
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A brief history of mass hacks



Enterprise cybersecurity tools, such as routers, firewalls, and VPNs, exist to protect corporate networks from intruders and malicious hackers, something that is particularly important in today's age of widespread remote and hybrid working.

But while pitched as tools that help organizations stay safe from outside threats, many of these products have time and again been found to contain software bugs that allow malicious hackers to compromise the very networks these products were designed to protect.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

These bugs have been blamed [for an explosion in mass-hacking campaigns](#) in recent years, whereby malicious hackers abuse these often easy-to-exploit security flaws to break into the networks of thousands of organizations and steal sensitive company data.

We've put together a brief history of mass hacks, and will update this article when more inevitably come to light.

January 2023: Fortra file-transfer tool hacks hit 130 organizations

One of the first mass hacks of this decade saw [a notorious ransomware crew exploit a vulnerability in](#)

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[Fortra's GoAnywhere](#) managed file transfer software, a product used by companies to share large files and sensitive datasets over the internet. The prolific Clap ransomware gang exploited the bug to compromise more than 130 organizations and steal the personal data of millions of individuals. The vulnerability was exploited as a zero-day, which means Fortra had no time to fix it before it came under attack. Clap later published data stolen from victim organizations who did not pay the hackers a ransom. Hitachi Energy, [security giant Rubrik](#), and Florida-based health tech organization NationBenefits — [which saw the data of more than three million members stolen in the attack](#) — reported intrusions resulting from the buggy software.

May 2023: MOVEit flaws allowed theft of 60 million people's data

The [mass hack of MOVEit](#) remains one of the [largest mass breaches of all time](#), with hackers abusing a flaw in another widely used file transfer software, developed by Progress Software, to steal data from several thousand organizations. The attacks were again claimed by the Clap ransomware group, which exploited the MOVEit vulnerability to steal data on more than 60 million individuals, according to cybersecurity company [Emsisoft](#). U.S. government services contracting giant Maximus was the largest victim of the MOVEit breach after confirming that hackers accessed the protected health information of [as many as 11 million individuals](#).

October 2023: Cisco zero-day exposed thousands of routers

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The mass hacks continued into the second half of 2023, with [hackers exploiting an unpatched zero-day vulnerability in Cisco's networking software](#) throughout October to compromise tens of thousands of devices that rely on the software, such as enterprise switches, wireless controllers, access points, and industrial routers. The bug granted attackers “full control of the compromised device.” While Cisco didn't confirm how many customers had been affected by the flaw, Censys, a search engine for internet-connected devices and assets, says it had observed almost 42,000 compromised devices exposed to the internet.



IMAGE CREDITS: RAMON COSTA/SOPA IMAGES/LIGHTROCKET / GETTY IMAGES

November 2023: Ransomware gang exploits Citrix bug

Citrix NetScaler, which large enterprises and governments use for application delivery and VPN connectivity, became the [latest mass-hack target](#) just one month later in November 2023. The bug, known as “CitrixBleed,” allowed the Russia-linked ransomware gang LockBit to extract sensitive information from affected NetScaler systems at big-name firms. Aerospace giant Boeing, law firm Allen

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cybersecurity company Volexity found that more than 1,700 Ivanti appliances worldwide were exploited, affecting organizations in the aerospace, banking, defense, and telecoms industries. U.S. government agencies with affected Ivanti systems in operation were ordered to immediately [take the systems out of service](#). Exploitation of these vulnerabilities has since been [linked](#) to the China-backed espionage group known as [Salt Typhoon](#), which more recently was found to have hacked into the networks of at least nine U.S. telecommunications companies.

February 2024: ConnectWise customers hacked thanks to bugs in remote access tool

In February 2024, hackers [took aim](#) at two “easy-to-exploit” vulnerabilities in ConnectWise ScreenConnect, a popular remote access tool that allows IT and support technicians to remotely provide technical assistance directly on customer systems. Cybersecurity giant Mandiant said at the time its researchers had observed “identified mass exploitation” of the two flaws, which were being abused by various threat actors to deploy password

stealers, backdoors, and in some cases, ransomware.

Hackers hit Ivanti customers (again) with fresh bugs

Ivanti made headlines again — also in February 2024 — when attackers exploited another vulnerability in its widely used enterprise VPN appliance [to hack its customers](#). The Shadowserver Foundation, a nonprofit organization that scans and monitors the internet for exploitation, told TechCrunch at the time it had observed more than 630 unique IP addresses attempting to exploit the server-side flaw, which allows attackers to gain access to devices and systems ostensibly protected by the vulnerable Ivanti appliances.

November 2024: Palo Alto firewall bugs put thousands of firms at risk

Later in 2024, hackers compromised potentially thousands of organizations by exploiting [two zero-day vulnerabilities](#) in software made by cybersecurity giant Palo Alto Networks and used by customers around the world. The vulnerabilities in PAN-OS, the operating system that runs on all of Palo Alto's next-generation firewalls, allowed attackers to compromise and exfiltrate sensitive data from corporate networks. According to [researchers at security firm watchTowr Labs](#), who reverse-engineered Palo Alto's patches, the flaws resulted from basic mistakes in the development process.

December 2024: Clon compromises Cleo customers

In December 2024, the Clop ransomware gang targeted yet another popular file transfer technology to launch a fresh wave of mass hacks. This time, the gang [exploited flaws](#) in tools made by Cleo Software, an Illinois-based maker of enterprise software, to target dozens of the company's customers. By early January 2025, [Clop listed almost 60 Cleo companies](#) that it had allegedly compromised, including U.S. supply chain software giant Blue Yonder and German manufacturing giant Covestro. By the end of January, Clop added another 50 alleged Cleo mass-hack victims to its dark web leak site.



IMAGE CREDITS: ALEX KRAUS/BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

January 2025: New year, new Ivanti bugs under attack

The new year began with Ivanti falling victim to hackers — [yet again](#). The U.S. software giant alerted customers in early-January 2025 that hackers were exploiting a new zero-day vulnerability in its enterprise VPN appliance to breach the networks of its corporate customers. Ivanti said that a “limited number” of customers were affected, but declined to say how many. The Shadowserver Foundation [says its data shows](#) hundreds of backdoored customer systems.

Fortinet firewall bugs exploited since December

Just days after Ivanti's latest bug was disclosed, Fortinet confirmed that hackers had separately been exploiting a vulnerability in its firewalls to break into the networks of its corporate and enterprise customers. The flaw, which affects the cybersecurity company's FortiGate firewalls, had [been "mass exploited" as a zero-day bug since at least December 2024](#), according to security research firms. Fortinet declined to say how many customers were affected, but security research firms investigating the attacks observed intrusions affecting "tens" of affected devices.

SonicWall says hackers are remotely hacking customers

January 2025 remained a busy month for hackers exploiting bugs in enterprise security software. SonicWall said in late January that as-yet-unidentified hackers are exploiting a newly discovered vulnerability in one of its enterprise products [to break into its customer networks](#). The vulnerability, which affects SonicWall's SMA1000 remote access appliance, was discovered by Microsoft's threat researchers and is "confirmed as being actively exploited in the wild," according to SonicWall. The company hasn't said how many of its customers have been affected or if the company has the technical ability to confirm, but with [more than 2,300 devices exposed to the internet](#), this bug has the potential to be the latest mass hack of 2025.

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Carly Page

Sr. Reporter, Cybersecurity | X   

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Hackers are exploiting a new Fortinet firewall bug to breach company networks

Carly Page — 1:25 PM PST · January 14, 2025

Security researchers say malicious hackers have been exploiting a newly discovered vulnerability in Fortinet firewalls to break into corporate and enterprise networks.

In an [advisory published Tuesday](#), security product maker Fortinet confirmed that a critical-rated vulnerability in its FortiGate firewalls, tracked as CVE-2024-55591, is “being exploited in the wild.”

Fortinet made patches available, but security researchers have warned that hackers have been mass-exploiting the vulnerability as a zero-day — meaning before Fortinet was aware of the vulnerability and made fixes available — since December.

This is the latest example of hackers exploiting a vulnerability in a popular enterprise security product designed to protect corporate networks from intruders. News of the Fortinet bug lands days after it was revealed that [attackers are exploiting a separate zero-day flaw in Ivanti VPN servers](#) that allows access to customers’ networks.

Cybersecurity company Arctic Wolf said in a [blog post](#) last week that its researchers observed a recent “mass exploitation” campaign affecting Fortinet FortiGate firewall devices with management interfaces exposed to the public internet.

Stefan Hostetler, lead threat intelligence researcher at Arctic Wolf, confirmed to TechCrunch that this observed exploitation is linked to the newly confirmed CVE-2024-55591 vulnerability in Fortinet firewalls.

Hostetler told TechCrunch that Arctic Wolf had “observed a cluster of intrusions affecting Fortinet devices in the tens,” but notes that this only represents a “limited sample compared to the total actual number of devices that were likely affected.”

“The evidence points to an effort to exploit a large number of devices within a narrow time frame,” added Hostetler.

When reached by TechCrunch, Fortinet spokesperson Tiffany Curci declined to say how many Fortinet customers were compromised as a result of this hacking campaign, but said that the company was “proactively communicating with customers.”

It’s also unclear who is behind the attacks on Fortinet firewalls, but cybersecurity researcher Kevin Beaumont [writes on Mastodon](#) that the vulnerability is “under exploitation by a ransomware operator.”

Hostetler said that ransomware attacks exploiting the bug are “not off the table,” noting that in previous research, Arctic Wolf “observed affiliates of ransomware groups such as Akira and Fog using some of the same network providers to establish VPN connectivity.”

In [a brief statement](#) on Tuesday, U.S. cybersecurity CISA urged Fortinet customers to update any affected devices.

In September, [Fortinet disclosed a breach](#) involving customer data after an attacker accessed “a limited number of files” stored on a third-party shared cloud drive belonging to the organization.

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